

SAHPATHI 2018

JHARKHAND CHAPTER



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Introduction

Basic Idea

Sahpathi is the extension of the Road Teachers project, which was organized in June-July 2016 and continued in June- July 2017. The third phase which is also the fourth batch of Sahpathi was organized in the June- July 2018. In the last two years, it was conducted in selected residential schools for children from Scheduled Tribe (ST) and Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG) households, run by the Department of Welfare, Government of Jharkhand. Sahpathi 2018 saw its collaboration with the Department of Tribal and Scheduled Caste Development, Government of Chhattisgarh. The programme was also assisted by Chaupal Gramin Vikas Prashikshan Evam Shodh Sansthan in Sarguja district, Chhattisgarh where the residential schools were located. Students from various colleges and universities across the country participated as volunteers in the programme. The volunteers stayed in the residential schools with the children and conducted curricular, co-curricular and extra-curricular activities and made observations about the schools. The idea is that volunteers and students in the residential schools become ‘*Sahpathis*’ (that is, ‘co-learners’) during the course of the programme and together explore possible ways of supporting and reviving these schools. The programme was initiated by Jean Drèze and Reetika Khera and, this year, coordinated by Apurva Bamezai, Akash Ranjan, Sabah Maharaj and Snehashish Das.¹

When and Where

The programme for this year was conducted from 16th June to 2nd July 2018. It started with an orientation workshop on the 16th and the 17th of June and ended with a debriefing workshop on the 2nd of July. Volunteers were posted in residential schools for Adivasi children, managed by the Department of Welfare, Government of Jharkhand and Department of Tribal and Scheduled Caste Development, Government of Chhattisgarh or (in some cases) entrusted by it to NGOs. The programme received cooperation from both of the Departments from the very beginning. Initially, the programme focused on a few districts of Jharkhand relatively close to Ranchi (Ranchi, Gumla, Latehar, Khunti and Lohardaga). However, this year, Sahpathi could only focus

¹ For any information related to the Sahpathi Programme, please write to snehashishdas739@gmail.com or a.bamezai@gmail.com.

on the schools of Gumla, Latehar and Lohardaga district, and extend itself to Sarguja district of Chhattisgarh. The 11 schools that were covered are:

Schools from Jharkhand:

1. Jobhipat, Gumla district (Boys).
2. Sakhuapani, Gumla district (Boys).
3. Chapatoli, Gumla district (Girls).
4. Netarhat, Latehar district (Girls).
5. Lohardaga, Lohardaga district (girls).

Schools from Chhattisgarh:

1. Marya, Sarguja district (Co-education).
2. Govindpur, Sarguja district (Boys).
3. Baijnathpur, Sarguja district (Boys).
4. Tirang, Sarguja district (Boys).
5. Chirga, Sarguja district (Girls).
6. Bhatko, Sarguja district (Girls).

Activities

The volunteers were expected to teach, play and conduct activities in the schools, help them in daily routines, develop innovative teaching methods or teaching aids, make the school environment more child-friendly, coordinate with the teachers and find ways of improving the school.

Volunteers were free to decide on the activities they wished to conduct and ways of engaging with the schools according to what they thought suited the school best.

An orientation and training session over 1.5 days was organized for the volunteers before they departed for the schools, and a day-long debriefing session was conducted at the end of the volunteers' stay. The training programme is discussed briefly in Annex A.



Photos from the Orientation Training Workshop and the Debriefing, Sahpathi 2018

Resources

With the approval and support of the respective Department(s), the residential schools agreed to arrange local hospitality (food and accommodation) for the volunteers. Travel expenses to and

from Jharkhand (train fare, sleeper class by the shortest route) were reimbursed to those who stayed for at least two weeks and requested reimbursement.

Funding

We collected individual donations with no strings attached for this purpose.

Volunteers' Details

A total of 37 volunteers participated in Sahpathi 2018. Details of the volunteers are mentioned in the list given below.

Sl. No	Name	Email Id	Gender
1	Arunabh Konwar	adkpost17@gmail.com	M
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25	Raginee Sarmah	ragineenidhi@gmail.com	F
26	Ishanee Sarmah	ishaneenaina@gmail.com	F
27	Sayam Siddha	marsha.oleman@gmail.com	F
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34	Navya Sharma	navyasharma2703@gmail.com	F
35	Natasha Khan	natasha.khan@niser.ac.in	F
36	Padmini Rajoria	prajoria811@gmail.com	F
37	Hemashree Alase	psychosniperhema@gmail.com	F



Team Sahpathi 2018 (Coordinators, Volunteers and the Well Wishers)

Beyond July 2018

This is not just a one-off project, but an experiment aimed at exploring possible ways of helping the concerned schools on a more sustained basis. All the volunteers have been asked to write a short note about their experience, observations and suggestions. This will help us to assess the state of the schools and find ways of supporting them in the future. We are also hoping that some volunteers will write for a wider audience.

Activities with Students

Based on the past experiences of Road Teachers 2016 and Sahpathi 2017, most activities panned out according to that. In the fourteen days that the volunteers spent in the schools, they helped the teachers in curricular and various other daily activities. All the schools had a looming problem of understaffing. Apart from the co-curricular and extra-curricular activities conducted last year, this year saw the introduction of a new range of activities. Further, volunteers also facilitated finding ways for dealing with small-scale infrastructural issues and inadequacies. Most groups made it a point to conduct ‘sensitisation’ and ‘awareness’ sessions, with some groups further trying to document some life stories of the students, as they narrated and wrote about themselves. The focus of the volunteers this year was mostly engaging with the teachers and students to better understand the concerns of the school. Volunteers also recorded detailed school-wise observations of the changes after the Road Teachers 2016 as well. Since Sahpathi had a few volunteers from Road Teachers as well, this helped maintain the continuity in the programme. A development of collective understanding in terms of understanding the role of the volunteers as facilitators of change and ‘co-travelers’ in that journey was seen in Sahpathi.

Curriculum-Related

- Exploring creative ways of using NCERT books
- Mathematic skill training, sessions on using maps, science experiments
- Sessions for bridging the language gap between the mother tongues of the students and Hindi/English
- knowledge of alphabets and numbers
- Discussion on “discrimination” based on the curriculum
- Poetry recitation in Hindi and English, creative writing sessions

Co-Curricular and Extra-Curricular Activities

- Spin a yarn activity- story creating activities
- Sessions for classes 8th to 10th around topics- gender equality, sex education, idea of beauty, menstrual hygiene, good touch- bad touch, witch hunting

- Classes on mental mathematics
- Discussions on witch hunting
- Sharing of thoughts about the study, life and problems in this campus
- Session on Science and Superstition
- Session on dream, desires and ambitions
- Tobacco and alcohol sensitization sessions
- Sessions on Adivasi identity and struggle
- Painting competition
- Essay competition
- Science and other exhibition
- Career counseling session
- Art and Craft
- Theatre activities
- Physical training and Yoga sessions
- Basic computer training using laptops
- Sports matches
- Reading and storytelling sessions
- Training in use of dictionaries
- Singing songs in tribal languages and different regional languages of India
- Presentation skills training
- Reciting life histories
- Sharing and presenting folktales, folksongs and folkdances
- Movie screenings
- Letter writing
- Finance and keeping track of budget
- Introduction to the concept of democracy, Constitution of India, the Preamble and Fundamental rights

- Gender sensitization, sessions on beauty, gender stereotypes and sexuality
 - Menstruation and reproductive health awareness
 - Environmental awareness
 - Sessions on sexual harassment and methods of redressal
 - Sessions on exploitation, child rights and Right To Education (RTE)
 - Discussion around Indian economy.
 - Personal health and hygiene
 - Sessions on witch hunting, superstition and exploitation
 - Intra-school and inter- school sports matches
 - Health camps, awareness march in the neighborhood
 - Visit to the local PHC, hospital
- Pictures of the activities are attached in the following pages.



Post Card Delivery

Cultural Activities



Sessions on Gender and Sex Education



Yoga





Fun Games



Health Checkup Camps





Theatre Activities



Painting Sessions



**Football Match
Between Jobhipat
And Sakhuapani
Schools**





Computer Education Sessions



Movie Screenings

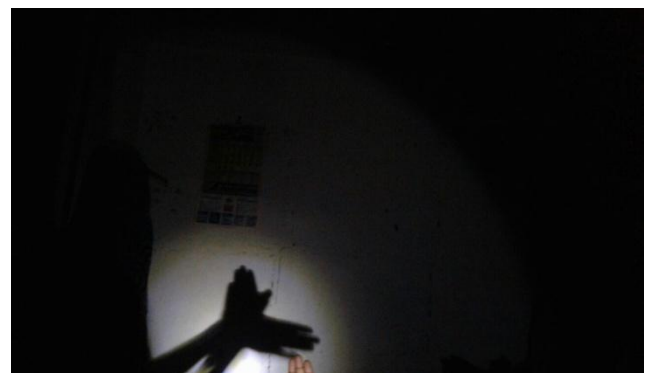


Science Exhibition



Sessions on Human Body parts

Shadow Art



Observations, Issues and Concerns

Volunteers observed the schools in comparison with last 2 years. The general observations about all the schools are discussed here, followed by school-wise observations.

Infrastructure

- Lack of basic amenities such as:
 - Electricity
 - Water
 - Functional toilets and bathrooms
- Lack of maintenance :
 - Buildings in disrepair; abandoned
 - Under-utilised buildings
- Boundary wall- broken or missing
- Services not provided on time despite of number of times of request by the school administrations.

Food

The revised budget and new prescribed menu have improved both the quantity and quality of food in general in the schools. However, certain problems still persist and certain new issues have come up in the last one year.

- Insufficient cooking staffs.
- Previously FCI, now private suppliers, the supplier monopoly in market.
- Regarding the revised menu:
 - Inadequacy of food.
 - Health incompatibility of children with certain food items like fried *pakodis* served for evening snacks.

- No nutritional value of certain food items, imbalanced meals in some cases with too many oily items in the menu
- The special training required for certain items like *idli* not provided to the cooks, possibility of extra work pushes the burden of preparing some items on the children.
- Unavailability of ingredients due to location of the schools.

Staffing and Pedagogy

- Inadequate teaching staff; especially subject teachers.
- Salaries not being provided to teachers and staffs on time.
- Transfer and promotion issues.
- Hostel work, clerical work done by teachers; no additional warden, clerk.
- Missing security guards.
- Low salaries for NGO-run schools.
- Inadequate sports curriculum and materials in the schools.
- Nexus between private tuitions and schools: teachers are seen to be subcontracting workload to people from private tuitions in nearby villages, who charge some amount to each student for the classes, especially for 9th and 10th classes.

Biometric Attendance - related issues

The system of marking biometric attendance is placed in almost all the schools and most of the schools are facing issues with the system.

- Lack of electricity and connectivity hampering the functioning of the biometric machines
- Loss of time in marking biometric attendance
- Problem of the students ‘unrecognized’ by the system

[An article](#) on this issue by Prof. Reetika Khera was carried by Prabhat Khabar in its Ranchi edition on July 18, 2017.

Child Labor and Harassment

- At almost all the schools visited by volunteers, it was observed that the students are made to do a lot of hard manual tasks and also do teachers' personal chores often at the cost of their own studies or health. Some schools subject students to corporal punishment. Cases of treating physically unwell students by calling Ojhas etc. were observed in some schools.
- Students are also seen to be subjected to corporal punishment.

Health

Regular Health Checkups don't happen in the schools. Schools also don't have first aid in the campus.

Feedback Table

- A table with feedback received from the volunteer groups about each of the 8 schools visited as part of the programme is presented below.

SL NO.	Details	Jobhipat	Sakhuapani	Chapatoli	Netarhat	Lohardaga
1.	Does the school have the following facilities? <i>[Y = Yes; N = No; N/A = Unclear]</i>					
	Electricity connection	N	Y	Y	Y	Y
	Regular electricity supply	N	N	N	Y	Y
	Handpump(operational) with clean water	N	N	Y	Y	Y
	Functional toilet(s) for children	N	N	Y	N	Y
	Functional bathroom(s) for children	N	Y	Y	N	Y

	Functional computer(s)	N	N	N	N	N
	Functional library	N	N	N	N	N
	Functional science lab	N	N	N	N	N
	Boundary wall with gate	N	Y	N/A	Y	Y
	Cooking place in hygienic condition	N	N	Y	Y	Y
	Play ground	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
	Adequate play equipments for all age groups	N	N	N	N	Y
	First aid box	N	N	Y	N	Y
2.	How many of the following water supply facilities does the school have? <i>[If none, write "0".]</i>					
	Functional handpump(or any other source in school premises) with clean water	0	0	2	2	1
	Functional handpump with contaminated water	0	0	0	0	0
	Non-functional handpump	0	1	1	0	0

	Functional borewell	0	1	1	1	1
3.	How many functional toilets, accessible to children, does the school have?	0	0	10	0	5
4.	Do children normally have a bath inside or outside the school campus? <i>[1 = Inside; 2 = Outside; 3 = Both; 9 = Unclear]</i>	2	3	1	2	1
5.	How many persons have been appointed in the following posts?					
	Teachers (regular)- M	6	7	4	0	4
	Teachers (regular)- F	0	0	3	0	3
	Teachers (contract)- M	2	3	2	0	0
	Teachers (contract)- F	1	0	4	5	0
	Hostel warden	0	0	1	1	1
	Cooks	4	4	4	2	2
	Watchman/security guard	0	0	1	1	0
	Cleaning or maintenance staff	4	0	0	0	0
	Accountant	0	0	1	0	0

6.	Did the Principal attend school regularly during your stay? <i>[Y = Yes; N = No; N/A = Unclear]</i>	N	N	Y	N	Y
7.	On an average day, how many teachers were present at the school during teaching hours?	6	5	8	5	6
8.	Did the school conduct any health checkups in the last 6 months? <i>[Y = Yes; N = No; N/A = Unclear]</i>	N	N	N/A	N	N
9.	How would you rate the nutritious value of the food that was being given to children? <i>[1 = Very good; 2 = Good; 3 = So-so; 4 = Poor; 5 = Very poor]</i>	3	3	3	4	2



Hostels without Protective Boundaries in Jobhipat School



Toilets being built in Jobhipat school without ensuring water supply to the school yet

Water has to be brought from the stream down 1.5 kms in Jobhipat school



Unused Water Tap and Solar Panels in Jobhipat School



Wastages of building materials





Condition of the Toilets in Sakhuapani and Chapatoli Schools



Lack of Eating Spaces or Mess Rooms causing unhygienic Food Habits in Sakhuapani School



Insects in the Food



Vacant rooms in Chapatoli School



Broken benches in Netarhat School

**No Garbage Disposal inside
the School Campuses leads
to Unhealthy Environment**



**Girls Engaging in the Domestic Chores of the
Residential Teachers in Netarhat School**



**Girls in Netarhat School
Serving Food in the
Mess and Deweeding
the campus**



School-wise Observations

Following are further school-wise observations by volunteers, gathered and compiled from the team reports as observed in June- July 2018.

Jobhipat

Infrastructure

- There is no boundary wall for the hostel which causes major security issues. Many windows of one of the two hostel buildings are broken. There is no firm gate, which allows stray animals to enter the school.
- No water supply in the campus. Students have to walk 1.5 km down the hill for defecating, bathing and fetching water. One electric water motor installed in the campus pumps out dirty water which is completely useless.
- The electricity run bore-well got destroyed due to electrocution during light fall.
- 3 toilets are under construction and projected to be completed by August despite of the fact that the issue of water supply has not been solved yet.
- No electricity supply.
- 32 solar plates were installed just 2 months back at RS 40 lakhs, but that worked only for a week. It's lying unused since then- despite of repeated calls no serviceman has appeared.
- An abandoned building stands in the campus which is at the risk of falling down anytime.

Food

- Some of the items prescribed in the revised menu cannot be prepared in the school due to unavailability of the ingredients. This is due inaccessibility of material due to the location of the school.
- Quantity of breakfast and snacks is often inadequate.
- The diet plan, according to the daily work the students do, is not adequate.

Staffing

- There are supposed to be 17 teachers on regular basis all the time to fulfil school requirement. But currently there are only 6, out of which 1 has been temporarily promoted to headmaster & thus hardly teaches in class & stays out of school on excuse of meetings.
- Rest 3 contract teachers are also appointed but they attend the class only for 2-3 days a week.
- Since for class 1st to 6th, there is not much strict subject division, so the 5 permanent teachers are taking all the subjects.
- In higher classes (7th to 10th) there is shortage of teachers, thus the primary teachers try to cover their syllabus up to the extent possible. No contract teacher to teach Sanskrit. Economics - To be taken by headmasters who is not regularly available in school. There are no warden and security staffs.
- There are 5 posts vacant for Hindi, Science, Mathematics, Economics and Physical Education in class 10th. 2 teachers' posts are vacant in the middle school, and the post of headmaster is currently occupied by Prabhari. The watchmen, cooks, helpers, peon and sweepers are underemployed.
- Due to understaffing, teachers have to do overworks like looking after mess and its maintenance, partially looking after children during hostel hours etc.
- Salary:- According to the 7th pay commission but, since it was applied in 2018. So the outstanding arrears of salary hike of last 2 years, still not reimbursed to the teachers.
- Promotions:- Jobhipat is an area lying in the hills of latehar-Gumla region of Jharkhand. So due to tough living conditions, low span of services available & a perception of historical naxalism struck area, people/teachers of towns stop their transfers to these areas. The permanent teachers of this school came here in 2007(~10 yrs back) & have got no promotion or transfers since then.

Other Issues

- Biometric Attendance System: 5 Computers & Biometric systems were sanctioned for the school, but due to unavailability of electricity, they're just depreciated in the store rooms.
- The textbooks for 9th and 10th classes usually arrive around 3 months after the beginning of an academic session.

- Harassment: Class 10th students bully & beaten class 8th & 9th students as the incidents have reported. Chhatra Mantralaya (Students' Parliament) got dismissed due to this conflict. Even the mess in charge got hit during the efforts to stop the menace. This happens due to problematic habit of Alcoholism / Drunkerdism in senior students.

Communication

- Hospital: No hospital or any doctor / paramedical staff.
- One non-specialized person having very less knowledge prescribes medicines in the hamlet.
- ATM / Bank: Not in the surroundings. Nearest ATM (20 KMs in Netarhat), Nearest Bank (~70 KMs in Lohardaga)
- Post Office: Not full-fledged but present in the hamlet.
- Market: Hamlet provides a very few items of confectionary. But other important services like pharmacy, PCO, Cybercafé, etc are not present.

Sanitation

- Unavailability of regular water supply is the biggest factor.
- Defecation / Washing: Open defecation near the waterfall ~3 KMs afar from school.
- Clothes / Utensils Wash: Students & other people of school & hamlet procure some water.
- of personal use once in morning & evening they go for freshening up (~ 5lt/per day)
- Low awareness of sanitation in students like;
- Washing hands before meal
- Wearing footwear all the time
- Washing hands after loo
- Many students are suffering from disease :
- Eye Veritation
- Viral Fever /Cough / Cold
- Headache
- Injury Infection

Sakhuapani

Infrastructure

- The kitchen and classrooms leak during the monsoons. A new hostel building is currently being constructed.
- Safe drinking water is unavailable in the school campus. The source of drinking water is a well in the campus which gets contaminated during the monsoons. No taps in the campus are functional and water from the nearby streams is used for all the chores.
- Due to unavailability of water, toilets don't function and the students bathe in the streams and defecate in the open.
- Toilets are made recently but they are not operational because of broken exit pipe. So, a lot of garbage has been put and hence unclean toilet.
- No electricity. Solar lamps in the campus are rarely functional.

Food

- Due to the inaccessibility of the region there is a huge difficulty in getting the required ration.
- The contractor system has degraded the quality of the food and the quantity received is also very less.

Staffing

- Teaching Staff: 7 permanent and 3 contractual teachers. Only 3-4 of the 7 permanent teachers are seen to be regular. No teachers for Mathematics, Sciences and English for the higher section.
- Teachers also have to maintain mess work, take care of books and utensils supply and also partially take care of the students in the hostel hours.
- There are only 4 Non-teaching staff for cooking, cleaning purposes.

Other Issues

- The nearest medical facility is 25 kilometers away, in Netarhaat. Unwell students are usually sent home for treatment. Health checkups are not conducted regularly.

- The inaccessibility of the region coupled with administrative neglect results in the school not receiving the entitled facilities regularly and in time. The textbooks for 9th and 10th classes usually arrive around 3 months after the beginning of an academic session.
- Students- teachers relationship was not healthy. There's a need of frequent parent-teachers interaction.
- Students help in cooking of whole school because the lack of cook stuff at daily basis.
- Sanitation is poor. Whole cleaning was done by under 8th class student itself even they do cleaning of class 9th and 10th hostel room.
- Electricity (solar power) are there but not with proper allocation. It also need to be proper allocated from class room to hostel room (240V 39 solar panel).
- There is a laboratory room for science practical but there is no any equipment and things for do science practical. It should be developed.
- There are lack of sports equipment like cricket kit, football kit and also lack of indoor games equipment like carom, ludo e.t.c. these all need to be fix.
- There is no any functional library. It has to be there with proper allocation of book.
- In the school they don't have common dining hall so they eat food either in hostel or outside every time without light. They need a dining hall.

Chapatoli

Infrastructure

- No electricity supply. The solar panels electricity connection is functional, but only for classes 7th to 10th. Primary wings don't have solar electricity connection. So there is no electricity mostly in the day time.
- Hostel doesn't have solar electricity connection. The other electricity connection (non-solar/ regular) usually functions for an hour or so in the day and is there throughout the night.
- Water availability in the washrooms is there only in the morning time.
- Hostel is in a very bad shape. It has inadequate tin roofs which leak during the rains, filling the rooms with water. The faulty drainage system in the hostel causes repeated clogging, especially during the monsoons.

- The existing boundary wall is precarious. Towards the backside there is no proper gate and the area is trepassable.
- No garbage disposal mechanism for non-biodegradable waste.
- Sahpathi volunteers from last year established a library in the hostel premises which remains shut now, with no proper record of where the books remain now.

Food

- Preparing some of the items prescribed in the menu takes a lot of time and mealtimes are delayed by an hour.
- Diet doesn't involve non-vegetarian food at all, despite being prescribed in the school menu. Justification provided from the school is that most students are vegetarians while we have observed otherwise. The school fails to provide food according to the school menu since they lack resources (menu involves Idli, etc but due to lack of a grinder they fail to make it). After interacting with the staff, it has come to notice that the quality and quantity of the food has been enhanced due to the volunteers' visit.

Staffing

- Four employees employed without any formal documentation and haven't been provided with stipend for the last seven months. These employees being namely, two cooks, one peon, one night guard.
- Only two permanent staff members were present when the school reopened.
- Students in classes 8th to 10th have difficulty in understanding English and Hindi because of being neglected during primary classes. During the volunteers' stay, it was observed that primary sections of the school rarely held classes - English being the most neglected subject, and most emphasis being put on Mathematics. Thus, it became understandable why the high-schoolers found comprehending English, extremely difficult.
- Most of the teachers are not only teaching subjects that they were originally recruited for but are taking classes of different subjects interchangeably. Therefore, middle and high school do not have regular classes of Social Sciences, Hindi and English.
- It has come to our notice especially in the primary section, that some students have difficulty more than others in comprehension and writing which requires special attention.
- The night guard doesn't stay in the campus all the time, but only during night hours. Daylight security seems compromised.

Child Labour and Harassment

- Children are made to engage in extensive labor, which is not part of their daily schedule. Children were seen cleaning and cooking food separately for the teachers, in the female teachers' quarters on a daily basis.
- They were also seen serving food and cleaning washbasins in the male teachers' quarters. Post-lunch hours which involved some free time for the students for relaxing and playing would be exempted from these children who are made to cook and clean for the teachers till late evenings.
- Students are also seen to be subjected to corporal punishment.

Other Issues

- Health: No regular health check-ups, reproductive health is neglected.
- Biometrics-related issues: 141/240 students are registered on the machines. The remaining either do not have Adhaar cards or are not seeded. Teachers' attendance can be recorded on the machine only till the battery lasts.
- Even after three, four months into the session, students are yet to receive their prescribed books (Specifically, children from classes 4th, 5th). Resource material for teachers, also haven't arrived yet.
- It has been observed that three years back, unsolicited, threatening visits from unidentified young armed men from nearby forests would enter the school scaring the young girls, and putting posters such as "20 girls required" on the school walls.
- During the weekly *bhajan* evenings, a girl seems to be possessed by supernatural forces wherein she beats students who refuse to participate in those *bhajans*. Teachers have normalized it by labeling it as a part of Adivasi culture; no intervention is made from the authority side.

Lohardaga

Infrastructure

- The school consists of a student quarters as well as a staff quarters. The student quarters were overcrowded with 5 to 6 students living in each small room. On the other hand, the staff quarters were completely unused and were basically utilized as storage area. However, a new building to be used as student quarters for high school students is under construction.

- The student quarters had 3 toilets and 3 bathrooms in dilapidated conditions. There was also a newly constructed bathroom and toilet facility next to the classrooms which were in good condition. Another such facility is also under construction.
- The school has a newly installed solar electricity system which is not functional.
- The school consists of 8 classrooms out of which 2 classrooms were kept locked up as a result of which the students of the 1st and 2nd standard and the students of the 3rd and 4th standards shared one classroom and attended lectures together.
- The blackboards in the classrooms are in dilapidated conditions. The school also does not have a library facility. The room allotted for library was used by teachers as staff room.

Food

- The school follows the diet chart consistently. The meals mainly consist of rice, dal, vegetables, egg, chicken and fish on allotted days.
- Due to inadequate kitchen staff, students often help in meal preparation skipping lectures and play time in the process.

Staffing

- The school was understaffed and appointment of more teachers is required.
- The teaching staff consisted of 4 male teachers and 3 female teachers out of which one of the male teachers was unable to teach the students owing to physical disability and his unqualified wife taught the kids on his behalf. The physically disabled teacher was present in the school for 3 out of the 13 days of our stay.
- Most of the teachers are under qualified and teach subjects in which they have no specialization. One of the female teachers was also the clerk as well as warden of the school.
- Some teachers were allotted to specific subjects and the rest used to take lectures in whichever class there was no other teacher and teach whatever subject they desired.
- The Principal resides in the student quarters along with another male teacher. The student quarters had a newly appointed warden who is also a teacher and clerk of the school.
- The Non-Teaching staff consisted of 2 kitchen staff and one peon. The kitchen staff was inadequate for a school harboring 112 students as a result of which the students regularly helped in cooking of meals often missing school in the process.

- One of the kitchen staff working on contract basis through an NGO has not received salary in the last 6 months.
- There was no security guard employed in the school.

Other Issues

- The school has a biometric attendance system which is not working. The school conducts manual attendance in the evening during prayer but not during lectures.
- There was no cleaning staff employed in school. The cleanliness of the school was maintained by the students themselves.
- Health check-ups are not conducted on a regular basis.
- A health check-up by the block hospital revealed that a majority of the students suffer from cavities, lice infestation, vitamin deficiency and anemia.

Netarhat

Infrastructure

- No running water: It came to the volunteers' notice that the girls ferry water for their daily usage from the borewell. They also collect waters from the taps attached to the water pump wherein clean water is available only in the early hours (till 7 o'clock). Since it is solar powered technology, the availability of water is directly dependent on sunlight which means shortage of water on cloudy days. Due to the unavailability of water in buildings, the girls took bath in the open, under the borewell or solar powered pump. The labourers working in the opposite school building as well as the boys from the school building would constantly stare (while the girls took a bath) and sometimes pass lewd remarks.
- There are no functional washrooms in the school or hostel buildings. Upon checking the condition of the present washrooms in the school building, it came to our notice that the washrooms require immediate repair/renovation.
- The benches and the desks in all the classrooms are in a dilapidated condition. Some of the broken benches are replaced with plastic chairs.
- The plaster of the roof of the school building has retained moisture. As such water keeps dripping from the roof in the classroom, becoming a source of inconvenience.
- Even though there is wiring and electrical appliances in every room, there is no electricity supply in the school building. The supply of electricity to the school building depends on the

visit of guests as well as official dignitaries. In addition to this, the lack of light in the non-sun facing rooms makes it difficult for students to continue classes.

- There is no system of garbage disposal or waste management. There were no dustbins to be found anywhere on the campus.
- There is no library or any space for students to read extra/co-curricular books or newspapers. There is no study room for students to work in post school hours.
- Students have no dining hall. They consume their meals in the open or in their rooms.
- There are no curtains in the girls' dorms, particularly the new hostel building where the windows are visible from the road.
- The back gate with direct access to the new hostel seems weak and can lead to easy trespassing.
- There is no concrete path from the back gate to the hostel which makes it difficult for the girls to stably ferry water and it is very muddy during rains.

Food

- The renewed diet chart is not followed at all.
- In the time span we spent at the school, majority of the meals comprised of rice and potato.
- The volunteers did not notice a variety of vegetables, protein sources and roughage.
- The quality in the food served remains questionable.
- The quality and the portions served to the children were below average standards.
- The children are served breakfast at 7:00 AM and lunch at 1:30 PM. In between there are no small meals served.

Staffing

- It is recommended that there should be a salary revision of the teaching staff to incentivise them to teach better. It also came to the volunteers' notice that the teachers are not paid regular salaries.
- The teachers are not supplied with syllabus at the beginning of the academic session.
- The school has employed five teaching staff. Five teachers have to engage five classes for five continuous hours. As such there is a dearth of teaching staff in the school. Out of these five teachers, two of them manage the hostels. Out of these two, one of them is the acting principal/

administrative in-charge. This hampers the process of quality delivery of education to the students.

- As mentioned earlier, there is no electricity supply to the school building. Hence, the two desktops in the school are non-functional. There is no teacher available to teach computer skills to the students.
- There is a dearth of non-teaching staff in the school.
- There is no safai-karamchari on campus, both school and hostel premises.
- There is nobody guarding the gates.

Teaching And Pedagogy

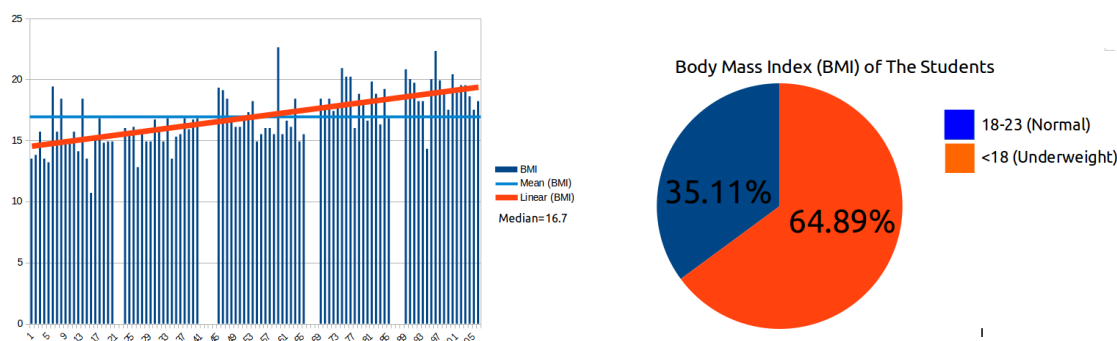
- Most of the class rooms we observed followed a rote learning pattern wherein the teacher would make the students repeat phrases out loud for a stretch of time.
- The role numbers are given in a descending order of merit. The classroom is organised accordingly. The top scoring students are seated in the front and hence have access to better desks and benches while the low scoring students are an easy target for being ignored by the teachers. Further, it has also been observed that relatively stable benches are placed in the front portion of the classroom where the top scoring students sit.
- The classrooms are dull and have no visually engaging aids on the walls of any classroom.
- There is no assigned supervised study hour in the hostel after the school hours.
- Academically weaker students are not paid extra attention by the teachers. There is also not any stay back provision post school hours for such students, who need special attention.
- There is no sports curriculum.

Health

- The State Dispensary which is nearest to the school (2-3kms) comes under Gumla District. The school comes under Latehar District. The responsibility of conducting health check-up at the school comes on Mahuadar State Dispensary, which is more than 40kms from the school. It remains for the school administration to submit an application regarding conducting a health check-up, and hence for Mahuadar State Dispensary to coordinate with the nearest State Dispensary for the same. At this end, the school administration has taken no such efforts. We

have also been informed from certain sources that the State Dispensary charges money for treatment from the school/students.

- **Body Mass Index:**



Other Issues

- Even though the school has two cooks, yet it was observed that the girls engage in the preparation of chicken curry twice a week. This involves cleaning the chicken, preparing masala, etc.
- It was also found out from certain authentic sources that the residential teachers exploit the students for their personal chores like ferrying water for the teachers, serving them food, washing their clothes etc.
- The children have reported that certain teachers use corporeal punishment.
- The students are handed over stationary items only once in a year. It does not confirm to the prescribed government entitlements. Students end up purchasing pens and pencils out of their own money.
- There is no first aid on campus. Students who are unwell are not given due medical care.
- There has been no health check-up in the past one year.
- Many students were wearing torn uniforms. The quality of the material of the uniform seemed questionable including their regular school uniform, PT uniform and night dress.

- Students of Grade 1 have not yet been given their backpacks. They end up carrying their required learning materials in a polybag or their hands.

Key Recommendations

While this section lays out some recommendations for each set of issues outlined earlier, **the overarching recommendation remains that the residential schools being run by the Welfare Department should meet the standards and norms mandated by the Right to Education (RTE) Act 2009.** In the three years that this programme has run, the volunteers have observed many shortfalls and the Department should strive to meet the minimum standards laid out in the RTE Act.

Infrastructure

- Electricity supply for every school should be ensured. Functioning of solar panels and immediate repairs when needed should be taken care of. Schools with only solar electricity should also be provided with more and extra solar lamps, so to be used in emergencies, and with other resources like kerosene, especially for the monsoons.
- It should be ensured that students receive all their yearly resources, especially textbooks, in time and in adequate numbers.
- Water supply in the campus for every school should be provided. Bore wells or motors to fetch water from nearby streams, if other sources are unavailable should be installed. Simple rainwater harvesting systems can be put in place in schools which have good rains (one such temporary system was put in place in Jobhipat by volunteers of Sahpathi of last year).
- Filtering or purifying system for safe drinking water should be installed in every school.
- Adequate number of functional toilets in schools and hostels should be in place. In schools where water is scarce, toilets using non-water sanitation can be built.
- The schools must install dustbins across the campus. There should also be a fixed site to deposit garbage, and separate organic and inorganic waste. This can be done by digging around the back garden for waste disposal. There is also enough space across the campus to cultivate a kitchen garden. As such, the organic waste can serve as manure.
- Library facilities should be made available in all the schools. In most schools, there is already a provision for the same but the system is dysfunctional. Students should also have access to newspapers at the library.

- Regular maintenance check should be ensured for every school. Road Teachers 2016 recommended that a position of a Maintenance Officer should be created for regular checks and auditing by a third party. More attention should be paid to the schools located in secluded regions. This officer can also check parents' involvement in School Management Committees as per the *Right to Education Act*.

Food

- The menu can be modified by altering the number of deep fried/ oily items and introducing more vitamins and proteins in the meals by including fresh fruits, vegetables, pulses, locally available mushrooms, puttu, eggs and meat.
- Some sort of training can be arranged for cooks who seem to be unequipped to prepare the specialized items in the menu. This will also work to reduce the burden on students to work in the kitchen.
- Quantity of food allotted to schools should be increased.
- Meal timings should be ensured and arranged with the scholastic routine to avoid huge gaps between two meals, especially for the younger children.
- School like Chapatoli, where non-vegetarian food is completely barred in the campus to maintain some ritual purity, should be dealt with immediately.
- The local contractor-based distribution system should be checked for reducing monopoly of the contractors.

Staffing

- Number of permanent teachers should be increased (by possibly accommodating contractual teachers on permanent posts) in accordance with the *Right to Education Act* and all the vacancies for non-teaching staff should be filled immediately. All the staff members should receive their monthly salaries on time.
- Creation of new administrative posts including that of a hostel warden, an accountant would relieve teachers of the additional duties on them and they can focus on teaching.

- The staff members working in schools situated at secluded regions should be given some kind of terrain allowance. Transfers of these staff members at regular intervals should be carried out.
- Residing female wardens in girls' hostels and security guards in every school should be appointed immediately. Adequate number of kitchen and cleaning staff should be appointed at every school at the earliest, to relieve students of the labour they are doing at the cost of their studies and health.
- The budget for the NGO-run schools should be revised as they lack severely on resources and the staff in these schools works on very low salaries temporarily.

Learning and Pedagogy

- The Anganwadi centers run under ICDS should be strengthened to accommodate more children before they enter the schools. These centers would equip children to adjust to the school environment more easily when they enter school at class 1.
- An active sports curriculum also needs to be introduced.
- Training sessions should be arranged for teachers for introduction of new interactive, hands-on pedagogy, especially for the primary sections and sensitization and awareness sessions should be arranged around gender, caste and constitutional entitlements for teachers and students.
- Local languages should be included in the scheme of teaching in schools, especially for the younger children. Folklores, tribal songs and dance forms should be a part of the curriculum.

Miscellaneous

- An anti-superstition campaign should be organized in all schools and treating physically and mentally unwell students by calling Ojhas at the school instead of providing medical help should be banned.
- Working at the residential quarters of the teachers, as well as corporeal punishment should be strictly discouraged. This can be done by constant counselling of the girls and teachers alike. Again, this invites a stringent monitoring.

- Clear norms should be set up about the kind of manual labour expected out of school children and strictly followed. Making students work at teachers' quarters at the cost of their health and studies should be treated as an offence.
- Regular health camps (two per year) should be conducted at every school and special attention should be paid to menstrual health in girls' schools.

Annexure A

Note on Training and Orientation of Volunteers

The orientation and training for volunteers of Sahpathi 2018 was aimed at equipping the volunteers with skills and pedagogical sharing with hands-on activities, giving a context of the geopolitics of Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, and brainstorming on planning the 14 days in the schools. Volunteers of Road Teachers 2016 and Sahpathi 2017 shared their experiences from last 2 years and two short videos made on Road Teachers/ Sahpathi were also screened.

The orientation and training workshop took place on the evening of 26th and for the whole day of 27th June, 2018.

The guest trainers and speakers invited to be a part of the orientation workshop of Sahpathi 2018 were the following:

Dayamani Barla is a journalist and activist from Jharkhand and has worked extensively for land rights of the indigenous tribals in the state. She is also known as the Iron Lady of Jharkhand. Her courageous journalism has been recognized world over and she is a recipient of the Counter Media Award for Rural India. Dayamani's journalism and activism can be a guiding light for anyone interested in human rights and egalitarian development.

Stan Swamy is a social activist, researcher and writer based in Bagaicha, Ranchi. He has been working extensively on Adivasi land rights and displacement. Trained in Sociology and Social Analysis, he has been a strong voice against the displacement faced by the Adivasis and Dalits of Jharkhand.

Jaimanti and Dolly Kumari are part of Jan Jagran Shakti Sanghatan (JJSS) in Araria district of Bihar. The Buniyaadi Nirman Initiative by JJSS has been in action in the area of education for children in Bihar.

Narendra Kumar Das works at Chaupal Gramin Vikas Prashikshan Evam Shodh Sansthan, Sarguja district, Chhattisgarh. He has been working on the issues of Right to Food, MGNREGA

etc from last 12 years and on Right to Forest from last 5 years. Chaupal Gramin Vikas Prashikshan Evam Shodh Sansthan also works in several schools in Sarguja district in the field of enhancement of quality education.

Binay Pattanayak is Education Specialist at UNICEF, India and is now based in the Jharkhand office. He works for quality improvement in school education through child-friendly inclusive schools and systems, and also engages in teacher education reform and community based school management as desired under the historic Right to Education Act, 2009. Previously, he was Chief Consultant (Pedagogy) to the Government of India for Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan. In this role, he guided the Center in Policy and Educational Planning and also he provided technical expertise to all the States and UTs in the areas of envisioning for quality education, curriculum/ textbook development, teacher training, teaching learning material development, effective classroom processes through active pedagogy, child – friendly learning assessment, effective use of educational technology, community participation, academic support to schools, educational research and quality management.